Old Dams Come Down, and Fish Swim Back

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In the northeastern United States, people are taking down old **dams**. Now fish called river herring are coming back.

A **dam** is a wall that blocks a river. **Dams** can store water or make electricity. But they can also stop fish from swimming **upstream** to lay their eggs.

Long ago, people in the East built many **dams** to power **mills**. By the mid-1800s, there were more than 65,000 **mills**. Scientists say these **dams** cost New England nearly 20 billion pounds of **alewives**, a kind of river herring.

Since 1912, more than 2,300 **dams** have been removed in the US. In 2024, Pennsylvania alone removed 27 old **dams**. Still, at least 35,000 **dams** block fish in the Northeast.

The results can be big. In 2025, about six million river herring returned to Maine's Penobscot River. That was double the number from two years before.

Fish **biologist** Nathan Furey's team puts tiny tags, about the size of a grain of rice, in fish to count how many make it **upstream**.

Word Treasure

dam -- A wall built across a river to hold back water.
upstream -- Toward the start of a river, against the flow.
mills -- Old factories that used moving water to power machines.
alewives -- A kind of small fish called river herring.
biologist -- A scientist who studies living things.

Background you need

A dam is a wall across a river that holds back water.

Some fish live in the ocean but swim up rivers to lay their eggs, so dams can block their way.

Many old dams in the Northeast were built long ago to power mills that are no longer used.

Break it down

WHO: People removing old dams and scientists like fish biologist Nathan Furey
WHAT: Old dams are being taken down, and river herring are coming back
WHERE: Rivers in the northeastern United States, such as Maine's Penobscot River
WHY: Dams stop fish from swimming upstream to lay their eggs

Why it matters

Rivers near your home could fill with fish again when old barriers are removed.

Test what you remember

1. What is a dam?

- (A) A boat
- (B) A wall that blocks a river
- (C) A kind of fish
- (D) A bridge for cars

2. What kind of fish are coming back?

- (A) River herring
- (B) Sharks
- (C) Goldfish
- (D) Tuna

3. Why were many dams built long ago?

- (A) To power mills
- (B) To keep out pirates
- (C) To grow rice
- (D) To make waterfalls for fun

4. How many old dams did Pennsylvania remove in 2024?

- (A) 2,300
- (B) 3
- (C) 100
- (D) 27

5. About how many river herring returned to the Penobscot River in 2025?

- (A) About sixty
- (B) About six million
- (C) About six
- (D) About six hundred

6. How big are the tags Nathan Furey's team uses?

- (A) About the size of a football
- (B) About the size of a grain of rice
- (C) About the size of a phone
- (D) About the size of a shoe

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: D 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):